

The War of Wages

A standoff between the armed forces and the Government over the Sixth Pay Commission threatens to snowball into a major issue as protests regarding the status quo get louder

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

On September 24, Chief of Naval Staff Admiral Suresh Mehta sent out an unclassified signal to his men. It spoke of how the navy was delaying the implementation of the Sixth Central Pay Commission (CPC) recommendations passed by the Union Cabinet. Two days later, it was followed by a similar signal from the Army Chief General Deepak Kapoor. Shaken by this unprecedented move, which some whispered was nothing short of a revolt, Defence Minister A.K. Antony pulled them up, following which the forces released 40 per cent arrears to their men.

The Government stepped in days later to announce the formation of a three-member committee headed by External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee, including Finance Minister P. Chidambaram and Antony. The services have also delayed the implementation of an-

other government order to implement the revised pay scales, preferring instead to wait for the recommendations of the committee. But what compelled the chiefs to cross the line in disobeying a Cabinet decision? "Such a situation has never been seen. It sets a bad precedent. Tomorrow, it could be used for any issue at the local level," says former defence secretary Ajai Vikram Singh.

Army officials insist the chiefs did not send out the service instructions which would implement the new pay commission from October 1 only to quell the possibility of unrest among the ranks. "The chiefs had no other recourse. They could not afford to let their men down," says Lt-General (retd) Vinay Shankar.

Protests from the armed forces have left the Sixth CPC hanging fire for over six months. The forces have painted the bureaucrats as villains of the piece for keeping them out of the panel that formulated the pay commission. This

WHINE LIST

■ Lt-cols are in Pay Band 3, lower than their counterparts in police and paramilitary.

■ Armed forces officers have lower grade pay than civilians.

■ Lt-generals left out of higher administrative grade while their civilian counterparts have been included.

■ Pension of persons below Officer Rank has been cut.

IN TANDEM: The service chiefs are standing fast against a Cabinet decision



EXPRESS PHOTO